companies met with President Obama and told him the NSA's surveillance of their networks was a threat to their businesses and the US economy.

When these companies learned, via Snowden's leaked documents, that an NSA program called MUSCULAR was providing back door access to their data without their knowledge, they were enraged. Brad Smith, general counsel of Microsoft, said in a blog post that the NSA posed an "advanced persistent threat," similar to Chinese government-sponsored hackers and

INCREASING USE OF ENCRYPTION

Snowden believes that when strong computer encryption becomes standard and everyone's communications are encrypted, mass surveillance such as that used by the NSA will have to end. Close to one year after the first leaked NSA documents were published, a survey by the network equipment company Sandvine showed encryption usage had increased. In early 2013, before the NSA revelations, 2.29 percent of all peak hour Internet traffic in the United States was encrypted. In May 2014, 3.8 percent of traffic was encrypted. The increase was greater in Europe, growing from 1.47 percent to 6.10 percent. Latin America saw the greatest increase in encryption use, growing from 1.8 percent to 10.37 percent.[11] Some of the jump was attributed to Internet companies using more encryption. For example, in September 2014, Apple and Google announced they were making encryption the default setting for all users. But individual use of encryption was also given as a reason for some of the increase. People were taking other steps to reduce their online footprints, as well, such as clearing their web browser histories.

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